

From cathedral to street

By the age of 17, Haydn had lost the pure treble voice required of choirboys. An incident in which he allegedly cut off the pigtail of a fellow chorister was used as a pretext for his dismissal. Thrown out with only the clothes on his back, he survived as a busker, singing serenades on street corners.

From this unpromising start, with determination, luck, and irrepressible talent, he built a musical career. While scratching a living in Vienna, he taught himself the basics of composition from manuals and the study of other people's music, notably the keyboard works of C.P.E. Bach. Exploiting a chance encounter, he made himself a useful servant to Italian composer and teacher Nicola Porpora, receiving in return advice on composition and contacts with potential patrons among the aristocracy.

Court life

Around the age of 27, Haydn secured his first full-time employment as musical director at the modest court of Count Ferdinand Maximilian von Morzin. It was for Count Morzin's small orchestra that he wrote his first symphonies. At last enjoying a regular income, he rushed into a marriage with Maria Anna Keller, the daughter of a hairdresser. The couple proved incompatible—Haydn had really been in love with Maria Anna's sister—and endured an acrimonious childless union, from which both sought relief with other lovers, until Maria Anna's death in 1800.

In 1761, Haydn moved his services to a far grander establishment, the princely court of the Hungarian Esterházy